

(L TO R) LAD, BHAVANI-
BALJEE, GHOSH AND
BRAGANZA AT THE TAJ
RESIDENCY, BANGALORE



Photographs by SANJAY RAMCHANDRAN

correct role. I have been in politics for the last 10 years and have seen the system deteriorating. The country has just one problem: attitude. With no role model, commercialisation has become the first priority.

Carlton Braganza (CB): I see a lot of young people who work hard and want to party harder. There has to be a balance where people can work and live in a society that doesn't question them. Everyone has their own mind. That's what democracy is all about.

Arundhati Ghosh (AG): I think there are many role models. In a small town like Asansol, where I come from, a lady spent her entire life educating Muslim girls from conservative families. She is a role model. I don't need the media to pick her up. It would be

**"RECENTLY, US
PRESIDENT BARACK
OBAMA ASKED
American children
to take a cue from
Indian children."**

VASANTH KUMAR BHAVANI

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CARLTON BRAGANZA

great if they do so, but if we stop looking only at the film industry and the political circles for role models, and open our eyes to the non-profit sectors—arts and culture, writers—we will find so many people who can be role models. Does role-modelling always need to be a mega affair?

SL: Even as a businessman, it's all about opportunities. Ratan Tata may be your role model, but his business model may be entirely different. We are comparing apples with oranges. We look up to national leaders. But some people get recognition on a platter. Today, people are famous because of the media, for right or wrong reasons. Because of that, when I travel to some places, people often regard me with *yeh politician hai, yeh chahta kya hai*. This is the general opinion about politicians. Many politicians do good work, but nothing of that is reported in the media.

Vasanth Kumar Bhavani (VKB): My role models in politics and social activism are different. To me, young people should aspire to be like Lord Ram.

AG: What are the characteristics that you look for in a young person?

VKB: Ram was a good son, a good husband, a good brother and a good king. Overall he was a good person.

KB: I am nobody to tell anyone what they should be like. As young people, I feel we have a responsibility towards the country. We should respect one another and the earth.

AG: When we talk about how young people should get involved in all walks of life, the presumption is that they are not as involved as they should be. I think young people are becoming more cynical because they feel that they have to be who they are in spite of the system.

SL: The truth is, opportunities are limited. In the West, the system takes care of you if you don't have a job. We don't have the right attitude. We all have different ideas, but we should think alike at least about our country. A sense of patriotism is missing.

CB: I don't think you can be forced to respect anyone or anything. You have to earn that.

SL: You got me wrong. No organ-